



RPI's Outdoor Programs & Rensselaer Outing Club Synchronized swimming Policies:

The intention of this document is to provide standardization of all indoor and outdoor synchronized swimming programs that are conducted by Outdoor Programs (OP) Rensselaer and Outing Club (ROC) at Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute. Synchronized swimming has the potential to be a dangerous activity. It is because of this inherent danger; the conduct of leaders and participants needs to be guided by accepted program standards. This document is designed to provide guidelines of conduct for synchronized swimming trip leaders which are accepted by professional practitioners throughout the greater outdoor education and recreation industry.

The standards put forth in the document are created with leading industry practices, years of combined experience, and the organization's culture/legacy in high consideration.

This document is organized by Program Overview and Guiding Principles, Trip Leader Qualifications, Trips Classifications, Approved Gear List, Proper Documentation, and a Document Amendment History.

Program Overview and Guiding Principles:

Role of the Leaders:

- When facilitating a synchronized swimming trip, leadership needs to be established to monitor for unwarranted risk on the participants, leaders, equipment, and institution.

Leaderships are defined as:

Assistant synchronized swimming Leader (i.e Assistant Leader)

Synchronized swimming Trip Leader (i.e. Trip Leader)

- Every synchronized swimming trip must have a synchronized swimming Leader and an Assistant synchronized swimming Leader as a minimum requirement.
- All Trip Leaders will always prioritize risk management during the program.

- Depending on the classification of difficulty of the trip, leadership is responsible for educating participants on important skills and pertinent information required to have a successful day.
- Leadership should take the time to seek adjustments for the needs of the participants.
- Trip Leaders should always act in a professional manner as a representative of the greater RPI and synchronized swimming community.

Risk Management:

- The sport of synchronized swimming contains elements of risk. Exposure to risk can be managed, but not eliminated from someone who engages in the sport of synchronized swimming.
- Location, weather, exposure, wildlife, terrain, equipment, physical ability, health concerns, distractions, and more all contribute to potential risks on a synchronized swimming program.
- Many incidents/accidents are unforeseen and could be avoided with proper preparation. It is a major focus of a synchronized swimming instructor to anticipate these factors and provide protection from these risks to the best of their abilities.
- Proper documentation of accidents/incidents as well as post trip summaries (GRO reports) aid in the effort to anticipate possible unnecessary exposure to risk.

Etiquette:

- Proper etiquette is important to all who participate in synchronized swimming so that access to these places can be maintained and effects on the natural environment can be minimized.
- Trip Leaders should be aware of the rules and expectations adopted by the synchronized swimmers at the trip location. (i.e. not taking up all the water, being noise conscious, etc.)
- Treat others with respect and dignity. Synchronized swimming Leaders model respectable behavior in the hopes of promoting good habits for other synchronized swimmers in their community.

Drugs and Alcohol Policy:

Those under the influence of a substance that alters their ability to follow directions or affects their independent decision making shall be removed from any ROC or OP synchronized swimming program. This includes but is not limited to drugs, alcohol, medication, etc.

General Program Guidelines:

- Trip leaders must abide by the guiding principles mentioned above.
- All trips will follow local and state laws and regulations regarding their intended activity.
- Swimsuit zones are to be established early and enforced by the program's participants.

- Participants should always remain under the supervision of trip leaders.
- No one should approach the edge of the water (10 feet) without the use of a tether or other appropriate protection.
- No synchronized swimming during severe weather conditions.
- Only leaders and assistant leaders may lead the group.
- No skinny synchronized swimming unless the trip is a designated skinny synchronized swimming trip.
- No synchronized swimming at night. Unless the performance is incredible
- The maximum ratio from participants to leader is 6:2
- Synchronized swimming trips need to be announced a week before they start.
- All other ROC and OP Policies are to be followed in addendum with Synchronized swimming Policies.

Synchronized swimming Trip Leader Qualifications:

Assistant Leader:

An Assistant Leader is an individual that has a developed understanding of essential synchronized swimming skills. They are learning the role of Synchronized swimming Leader, but at the moment do not have enough experience or knowledge to lead a trip. An Assistant Leader helps the Trip Leader in all trips leading responsibilities as well as takes the time to further develop their knowledge base.

To become an Assistant Leader for synchronized swimming programs, one must have:

- Participated in the ROC & OP Synchronized swimming Curriculum course (or equivalent)
- Outdoor Wilderness Leadership Course
- Wilderness First Aid certification
- CPR Certification
- The ability to synchronized swim outdoors.
- Can choreograph basic routines.
- An understanding of OP and ROC General and Synchronized swimming Policies.

Trip Leader:

A Synchronized swimming Trip Leader assumes the role of lead instructor of the synchronized swimming program. They are responsible for creating the appropriate atmosphere, managing risk, providing instruction/details, and organizing the synchronized swimming trip. It is important that the person in this role is well tailored to the responsibilities they have.

To become a Synchronized swimming Trip Leader, one must have:

- All the qualifications required for an Assistant Leader

- Passed the ROC & OP Synchronized swimming Curriculum written and practical assessments.
- Approval by the current ECOMM
- Demonstrated higher level knowledge of synchronized swimming concepts and practices.
- Ability to adequately communicate underwater
- Deep understanding of body positioning underwater
- Ability to demonstrate a variety of complex moves (i.e. dives, throws, flips, etc.)
- Ability to choreograph complex routines.
- Have participated in at least two ROC or OP Synchronized swimming Programs.
 - Synchronized swimming Trip Leaders need to have been a prior participant or assistant leader at a specific location before they can assume the role of a Synchronized swimming Trip leader for that specific trip.

Trip Classifications:

Introductory:

These trips are designed to introduce synchronized swimmers to the sport of synchronized swimming. Time is spent teaching basic skills and synchronized swimming knowledge. Topics that are normally covered are synchronization, basic tricks, synchronized swimming technique, leave-no trace, etc. Approaches should be kept short (under 15 min hike) and the chosen swims would be appropriate for beginner synchronized swimmers. The base of the water should have ample space for all synchronized swimmers and be devoid of any possible obstructions. An appropriate range of synchronized swimming difficulties should be around level 1 through level 2.

Intermediate:

Trips in this designation contain characteristics that would not be appropriate for a beginner synchronized swimmer. There is less focus on teaching lessons and participants should come with developed synchronized swimming skills and knowledge. Considerations that would make an Intermediate synchronized swimming trip would be, but not limited to; longer approaches, limited space at the water base, need to swim in wavy water, higher average available synchronized swimming difficulty (level 2-3) etc.

Advanced:

Advanced Synchronized swimming Trips are reserved for the highest level of permitted trip allowed by this document. Special attention needs to be given to the details of an Advanced trip before it is permitted to depart. A description of an Advanced trip would include elements of

long/exposed approaches, need for additional skills/knowledge (white water, level 3 through level 4 moves), exposure to harsh weather elements, long periods of 3rd & 4th class terrain, etc. Only participants with extensive experience in synchronized swimming should participate in an Advanced trip.

Packing Lists for Leaders:

Personal gear is the responsibility of the individual who is participating in the synchronized swimming program. If they need to borrow gear from the pit, it is up to them to acquire the gear according to Pit policies. Group gear will be the responsibility of the trip's leadership and will be borrowed under their names.

Personal/Individual Packing Lists:

- Swimsuit (matching)
- Swim cap
- Goggles
- Towel
- Closed-Toed Shoes
- Weather Appropriate Clothing
- Water/Food/Snacks
- Appropriately Sized Pack
- Sunscreen & Bug Spray

- Personal Items: camera, medications, sunglasses, etc.

Group Gear:

- Nose plugs
- Guidebook/water finder
- Copy of the Trip Sheet
- Permits/waivers (if needed)

Proper Trip Planning and Documentation:

Pre-Trip Preparations:

All trips that leave campus need to have in place specific documents to run correctly. It is important to have these documents in place for the protection of the participants, leaders, and organization. In not doing so, the leaders of those trips open themselves to become liable in the case of an incident/accident.

Permits:

It is unlawful for synchronized swimmers to access certain lands, parks, or cliffs without the possession of a granted permit. Federal, state, or local agencies may require permits to conduct synchronized swimming on land that is under their jurisdiction. There is the chance that permission is required on multiple levels of these agencies and could complicate the permitting process. It is the responsibility of the individuals who are facilitating the synchronized swimming program to make sure they are permitted to use the land in the intended way.

Waivers:

Every individual who is involved in an ROC or OP synchronized swimming program needs to have a RPI Outdoor Programs Assumption of Risk Informed Consent Release on file before the start of the program. These waivers allow the participant to make an informed decision about whether they want to participate in the program. Waivers highlight the foreseeable risks that are related to the activity and outline the anticipated conduct and expectations of participants.

Make sure that they are filled out to completion and that if the synchronized swimmer is under 18 years of age, that they have a parent's signature as well.

Fees:

If fees are to be collected for any means, students are to fill out a Change/Payment/Adjustment sheet and submit them to OP.

Outdoor Trip Plan:

A completed Outdoor Trip Plan must be submitted to the shared Outdoor Programs' Trip Sheet folder a week before the expected departure date. In the event of changes or cancellations/additions, an updated OTP must be on file before the trip departs. By not doing so, the leaders of the trip will be asked to meet with Outdoor Programs staff, a member/members of ECOMM, and the chair of said activity for review and course of action moving forward.

"Practice like you're not good enough to win. Perform like you're too good to lose." — Katie Ledecky